

A Prayer of Devotion

Scarlet Into Wool

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*The Book of the Prophet Isaiah
Chapter One · Verse Eighteen*

THE VERSE · KING JAMES VERSION

*Come now, and let us reason together, saith the LORD: though your sins
be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow; though they be red like
crimson, they shall be as wool.*

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BLOOMED RENDERING · THE PRAYER FORM

Come now — please, come —
and let us reason it out together, says YHWH:

though your missings-of-the-mark
be dyed deep as double-crimson,
they shall be made white as snow;

though they be reddened like the worm-dye,
they shall be as wool —
the Lamb's own covering, given back.

THE HEBREW SOURCE · MASORETIC TEXT

לְכוּ־נָא וְנִנְּכַחַהּ יֹאמֶר יְהוָה אִם־יִהְיוּ חֲטָאֵיכֶם כַּשָּׁנִים כַּשֶּׁלֶג יִלְבִּינוּ אִם־יֹאדְמוּ בְּתוֹלַעַ כְּצֶמֶר יִהְיוּ
*lechu-na ve-nivvachah yomar YHWH; im-yihyu chata'eichem kashanim kashaleg yalbinu;
im-ya'dimu chatola' katzemer yihyu*

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SOURCE RECOVERY · SEVEN CATCHES

לְכוּ־נָא · **lechu-na**

*come, please — imperative plus the particle of entreaty. Invitation, not summons;
the tone of one drawing equals to the table, not a sentence read from the bench.*

וְנִנְּכַחַהּ · **ve-nivvachah**

let us reason-it-out-together — niphal cohortative, the reciprocal mood. Not verdict pronounced but case argued through: God proposing dialogue with the accused.

חַטָּאִיְכֶם • **chata'eichem**

your missings-of-the-mark — the archery root the English “sins” compresses. Shots that fell short of what they aimed at; the target named by the falling short.

שָׁנִים • **shanim**

scarlets — the kermes double-dye, the deepest saturation of red. The tabernacle's thread and Rahab's cord wear the same word.

יִלְבִּינוּ • **yalbinu**

they shall be made-white — hiphil causative. Not fade-to-white but caused-to-be-white: divine action on the substance, not time's slow erosion of the stain.

תוֹלַע • **tola'**

the worm — the crimson-dye insect, crushed for its colour. The same word the Sufferer takes in Psalm 22:6 — I am a worm, and no man. The deepest red and the lowest name share one root.

צֶמֶר • **tzemer**

wool — the lamb's own covering. Not merely whiteness but material transformed: dyed cloth returned to living fleece. What the worm produced becomes what the Lamb provides.

THE RECOVERY

The English though your sins be as scarlet keeps the colour chart and loses the courtroom —

— ***lechu-na and nivvachah as invitation to reason, not summons to sentence***

— ***chata'eichem as the archery of falling short***

— ***yalbinu as caused-white, not faded-white***

— ***tola' to tzemer as worm-dye becoming the Lamb's wool***

The verse stages two transformations, not one: crimson to snow is a change of colour; worm-dye to wool is a change of material — from artificial intensification back to living covering. Forgiveness in this grammar is not the stain ignored but the substance remade, by the hand of the One who proposes to reason it out first.

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RESONANCES

Psalm 51:7

Wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow — David praying Isaiah's promise back in the same register.

Psalm 22:6

But I am a worm, and no man — tola', the same word: the Sufferer takes the dye-worm's name, crushed for the colour, so the crimson can become wool.

Isaiah 53:7

As a sheep before her shearers is dumb — the wool-bearer of the same prophet, silent under the shears.

Revelation 7:14

They washed their robes, and made them white in the blood of the Lamb — the paradox completed: whitened by blood, clothed by the Lamb.

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PRACTITIONER'S RESPONSE · A PRAYER TO SAY

***You have invited me to the table — I come.
Take the double-dyed and make it snow;
take the worm's crimson and make it wool:
remake the substance, not the story I tell about it.***

*Second witness of this passage in the corpus:
Bloom Sweep Phase II (23 June) · this Devotion (4 July 2026)*

— The Cartographer

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Hah-LEL YHWH